

Pahankanuwa Sermon #9

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

*Attanāva kataṃ pāpaṃ, attajaṃ attasambhavaṃ; Abhimatthati
dummedhaṃ, vajiraṃ vasmamayaṃ maṇiṃ.*

From:

Verse 161 from the Attavagga (Chapter on the Self) of the
Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

Some people, when they see someone who is leading a good life in society meet with death due to an unexpected accident or enemy hostility, doubt the value of a principled life, saying, "Look at what happened to him, despite living so well!" They weaken their conviction in the fruits and results of wholesome and unwholesome actions (*kamma*). They doubt in this manner because they lack a proper understanding of the subtle operations of the round of kamma.

The Buddha has pointed out that because of ignorance and *Taṇhā* (Craving) – covered by ignorance and bound by *Taṇhā* (Craving) – beings themselves are responsible for the wholesome and unwholesome deeds they perform selfishly with the notion of "self". He declared that they must experience their fruits and results, and that one day they will inevitably have to undergo those results. Although the subtle operation of kamma was not visible to other religious teachers, it was clearly visible to the Buddha. Therefore, on certain occasions when such wrong views arose in society, he would expound the past story related to the present event as an example – as empirical evidence – presenting such direct proof to the world. In doing so, he made use of the opportunity to rescue people from the path to woeful states and direct them towards happy realms and Nibbāna.

The background story related to the stanza we have chosen as our theme today is just such a case. While the Buddha was residing at the Jetavana monastery, there lived in the city of Sāvattthi a virtuous lay disciple named Mahākāla, who was a Sotāpanna (stream-enterer). He was accustomed to regularly observing the eight precepts. Eight days a month, he would come to the monastery, observe the precepts in this manner, and listen to sermons throughout the night. He was deeply devoted to this practice. One day, while this lay disciple was staying at Jetavana, during the night, a band of thieves broke into a nearby house. Hearing the noise as they were preparing to take the goods, the householders woke up and began to pursue the thieves. The thieves started running, dropping the goods here and there. One thief from this group was running along the road leading to Jetavana with the stolen goods he had taken. By that time, in the early morning, the lay disciple Mahākāla had come to the pond to wash his face. What did this thief do? He dropped the bundle of stolen goods right where the lay disciple was standing – probably intending to deceive the people pursuing him – and ran away. When the householders arrived and looked, there was the bundle of goods, and there was the lay disciple. They grabbed him immediately. Saying, "You broke into our house, and now you are pretending to listen to sermons here, posing as a lay devotee! You are a fake devotee!" they beat him mercilessly, killed him, and left him right there.

In the morning, novice monks came to that pond to fetch water. Seeing the lay disciple lying dead in this manner, they went and reported it to the Buddha: "Venerable Sir, that innocent lay devotee, the one who listens so well to the Dhamma, has been beaten to death and left there."

The Buddha said, "Monks, although from the perspective of this present life, the death this lay disciple received seems unfitting, according to the evil kamma he performed in the past, it is a perfectly fitting death." Then he related the story of the past.

In the past, at the entrance to a forest in a border village of the Kingdom of Benares, the king had stationed a certain royal guard because of the danger posed to travelers by the thieves living in that forest. What was the duty of this royal guard? It was to provide security to those who came and went along that forest path. One day, a certain man arrived there in a carriage, accompanied by his beautiful wife. As soon as the guard saw her, he conceived a desire for her and devised a plan to detain them. Even though there was plenty of time for them to travel, he said, "It is too late this evening. Therefore, stop for today. I will provide lodging at my house. You may leave tomorrow morning." But the man said, "No, no, there is still enough time. Please let us go." What did that royal guard do? Using his men, he stopped the carriage by force, and accommodated both the

man and his wife there, providing them with food and drink. During the night, he employed a scheme. He had his men hide a gem belonging to his house inside their carriage. He also made some noise to suggest that thieves had entered the house. The next morning, after the couple had departed, he raised an alarm, crying, "Now, search those who are about to leave this village! The gem in our house is missing. Thieves have taken it!" So the crowd went, intercepted the carriage, searched it, found the gem that they themselves had hidden, and presented the man to the village headman along with a false accusation: "This man stole the gem belonging to the royal guard who gave him lodging." The village headman too did not know the truth of the matter. Therefore, he ordered this man to be beaten and executed. The Buddha explained the consequences of that unwholesome act of taking life. As a result of that action, that royal guard boiled in the Avīci hell for a long time. As the remainder of that result, for a hundred lifetimes, he had to suffer death in the very same manner by being beaten. The Buddha revealed that this present occurrence was the very same, and that this story was about Mahākāla. Having shown this, he uttered the Dhamma stanza we mentioned earlier, along with a simile: "Monks, if a person is thus deluded and performs an evil deed himself, it will bring results in this manner."

Attanāva kataṃ pāpaṃ

attajaṃ atta sambhavaṃ

abhimatthati dummedhaṃ

vajiraṃ vasamayaṃ maṇiṃ

The meaning of this stanza is that the evil deed, born of oneself and produced from within oneself, destroys the ignorant person, just as a diamond born of rock cuts and destroys a hard stone.

Here, this stanza mentions a gem. It seems to have at least a slight connection to the story. But there is a much deeper meaning here. When it says "done by oneself," we see in this the sense of responsibility. In the past, that lay disciple, driven by selfishness, holding onto the notion of "self," performed that evil deed. Its inevitable result, the consequence of that false charge – for indeed he had framed an innocent man – was what he had to experience in this life. Thus, in the world, we often see innocent people being killed, as it were. But to the Buddha-eye, their past connection is often visible. We can understand this through this story. Especially here, we see that the lay disciple Mahākāla, having been a royal guard in the past, violated the third precept and the first precept by causing the destruction of life of an innocent man. It was the verdict of that framed charge. It was because of this that the thieves dropped the bundle of goods there. It was

kamma that prompted the thieves to drop it there. There is such a wondrous karmic connection in these events. We can see that this reality exists in everything we hear. We can contemplate this based on this story. Today, too, many such events occur. Events of the kind shown in these present and past stories are still seen in the world today. From this, we can understand that the law of kamma and its result is subtly hidden in every single one of these occurrences.

Next, we must particularly contemplate the deeper aspect of this. In this stanza, it is mentioned in several places: "done by oneself," "born of oneself," "produced from within oneself." Thus, "self" is specially mentioned. Indeed, this stanza comes in the section called the "Atta Vagga" (Chapter on Self). Many people easily translate this as the soul or self. However, there is a section in the Dhammapada about oneself. Many take it as a permanent soul. But what is spoken of here is not a permanent self. Some sophists and theorists raise the question: "If this Dhamma of the Buddha is *Anattā* (Not-self), how can one be responsible for one's own actions? How is responsibility demonstrated? After all, is it not someone else who experiences the results?" In this way, they try to argue their way out. But what is the idea here? It is the intentions (*cetanā*) that worldly beings generate while being covered by the veil of ignorance and bound by the fetters of *Taṇhā* (Craving). You may have heard the phrase: *"*Cetanāhaṃ, bhikkhave, kammaṃ vadāmi*"* ("Intention, monks, I say is kamma"). You must have heard this often. The Buddha pointed out that intention itself is kamma. Thus, through the ignorance that aids that intention – the feeling of "I and mine" – the notion or idea of "self" arises. Having established that notion of "self," when one performs actions thinking about one's own happiness, protection, progress, or gain, the results of those actions must be experienced by oneself eventually. Why is this? It is because **Vedanā** (Feeling) and mental activity are extremely rapid. The activity of the mind is incredibly fast. If this is directed towards the wrong side, we can imagine what great destruction it causes. If a driver of a fast-moving vehicle, out of negligence or drowsiness regarding his own hands and feet steering the vehicle, swerves the steering wheel even slightly, where does it end? The mind is just like that. It operates extremely fast. It is something that changes so rapidly that it cannot be compared to anything else in the world – called *"*lahuparivattaṃ*"* (swiftly changing). Therefore, if such a mind, according to the principle and method shown by the Buddha, inclines towards unrighteousness, unwholesomeness, and evil, then one will have to suffer grave consequences for a very long time. Not just in one lifetime – depending on the strength of that volition – the Buddha declares that the results of some kamma are experienced in this very life as **diṭṭhadhammavedanīya** (to be experienced in this life). The results of other kamma are

aparāpariyavedanīya (to be experienced in some future lifetime). In this way, the results of kamma are generally presented in various ways. However, when we contemplate deeply, the Buddha declares that the domain of kamma is unthinkable (*acinteyya*). The entanglement of kamma is that dangerous. The vast store of kamma performed in various lifetimes accumulates in this *viññāṇa* (consciousness). Deposited there, they arise as results some day. It is from this that we can understand the presence of such a perilous situation in this world.

If one pours poison upstream, when one takes water downstream, that poison can cause harm to oneself. This mental continuum (*citta-santāna*) is also like that. If some unwholesomeness – a defilement – is added to the mental continuum, it will surface as rounds of results over a long period, bringing suffering to oneself.

Now regarding this karmic result, there is a usage among our Buddhists called "kamma-sarikkhatā" (similarity of kamma and its result). We can point out a close similarity – a certain parallel – between kamma and its result, as shown by these two stories. Furthermore, even Western scholars who are waking up to this fact provide another simile for this operation of kamma. How it returns to oneself; how kamma performed by oneself returns to oneself. They sometimes point out that among some primitive tribes there is a weapon called the "boomerang". When that boomerang is thrown at an animal, it hits the animal and returns to one's own hand. In the same way, this kamma has a nature of turning back. If this kamma arose from a certain mental continuum, it returns to that very mental continuum. Therefore, one cannot escape by saying "there is no self." Why? Because we know that saṃsāra is the uninterrupted continuation of this succession of aggregates – even though there is no self – namely, form (*rūpa*), *Vedanā* (Feeling), perception (*saññā*), *Saṅkhāra* (Formations), and *viññāṇa* (consciousness). Within that succession of aggregates, some day, according to the law of kamma (*kamma-niyāma*), the results will emerge.

Since such a situation exists in the world, we must be especially mindful of it. In this degenerate age, the understanding, conviction, and faith (*saddhā*) regarding kamma of many people tend to disappear. It is often forgotten. That is how dangerous the condition of this world is.

That is why there is a valuable discourse expounded by the Buddha to constantly remind us of the law of kamma: the "Thāna Sutta". In that sutta, the Buddha points out five facts. We are specifically taking up the last fact mentioned there. To help one remember this kamma, to turn one's mind away from misconduct and direct it towards good conduct, he points out a practice called *"abhiṇham paccavekkhitabbam"*, as something to be constantly reflected upon. Whether lay

or ordained, female or male, this passage is presented as something to be reflected upon daily by everyone:

"Kammasakomhi kammaḍāyādo kammayoni kammabandhu kammaṭṭisaṇaṇo. Yaṃ kammaṃ karissāmi kalyāṇaṃ vā pāpakaṃ vā tassa ḍāyādo bhaviṣṣāmi abhiṇhaṃ paccavekkhitabbaṃ."

This is how one should contemplate. *"Kammasakomhi"* means – there too, if there is anything that can be taken as "self" or "mine," it is kamma alone. "Sako" means "one's own". Therefore, the general meaning is "I am the owner of my kamma." *"Kammaḍāyādo"* – "I am the heir to my kamma." *"Kammayoni"* – my place of origin, my source; I have originated from this kamma. When we say "I am everything," it is also intention. Taking everything as "I". That is what is meant by *"kammayoni"* – kamma also arises from the feeling of "I" and "self". *"Kammabandhu"* – kamma itself is my kinsman. What we call a support for a person is also this kamma. *"Kammaṭṭisaṇaṇo"* – kamma is my refuge, my support. *"Yaṃ kammaṃ karissāmi kalyāṇaṃ vā pāpakaṃ vā tassa ḍāyādo bhaviṣṣāmi"* – "Whatever kamma I shall do, whether good or bad, of that I shall be the heir." It is stated that this fact must be constantly reflected upon daily by everyone, whether lay or ordained, female or male.

As its result and benefit, it is stated that in the person who constantly contemplates in this manner, misconduct of body, speech, and mind – misconduct performed through body, speech, and mind – either completely disappears or becomes thin. That means the best way to abstain from such misconduct is to daily apply the law of kamma to one's own mind. "Mine" is kamma alone. When thinking in this way, one realizes that the things one grasps as "I" in various hurried situations in society, out of sudden ideas or impatience, are not what the Buddha has pointed out. It is the karmic momentum generated from within one's own mind that ultimately remains with oneself. It is that which brings happiness or suffering to oneself.

Accordingly, we must contemplate that the Buddha has shown the danger of this entanglement of kamma on many occasions in this manner. That is, usually, when we experience the result of a kamma, we do not realize that it is a karmic result, even though it is visible to the Buddha-eye. We think it is something done by others. Even the lay disciple Mahākāla, perhaps – we are not given the details, but since he was a lay disciple, he might have tried to calm his mind – but when the householders came and beat him to death in that manner, he might have felt some hatred, thinking, "Oh, they are killing me, an innocent man." Mahākāla too must have thought that he was innocent. There is room for even such an unwholesome thought to arise. But if we contemplate this deeply – according to

that passage – whatever disaster or enemy hostility comes to someone, one should think, "This is something I have done to myself." Now, who was the executioner of the lay disciple Mahākāla? It was himself. If we contemplate in accordance with the Dhamma, according to the principles of Dhamma, the cause of everyone's death is an unwholesome act of taking life performed by themselves in the past. That is how we must think. The proximate cause of everyone's death, the cause of death – here we are not talking about the mind at the moment of death – the cause of death is an unwholesome act of taking life performed by oneself in the past. Now this is clear here. The death of this lay disciple Mahākāla occurred due to a taking of life performed by himself. He himself was the executioner. It was not others. He himself was the executioner.

If we train ourselves to think in that way, we can easily bring the mind to equanimity in such situations, in accordance with the word of the Buddha. It may not be directly apparent to us. Because we do not have the power to see through ignorance, we do not see that "because of this kamma, these things are happening to me." But if we train ourselves to contemplate it as a general law – the word of the Buddha is true. The Buddha has declared it in this way. "This kamma is my inheritance. Kamma is my kinsman." Kinsman or enemy. Here, we must contemplate that wholesome kamma is one's kinsman, while unwholesome kamma is one's enemy. The Buddha has shown this too, when speaking about kamma:

Caranti bālā dummedhā

amittenev' attanā

karontā pāpakaṃ kammaṃ

yaṃ hoti kaṭukapphalaṃ

Thus the Buddha has declared. Fools of poor wisdom wander about, acting as enemies to themselves. They behave as enemies to themselves. *"Amittenev' attanā"* – behaving as enemies to themselves. Why? *"Karontā pāpakaṃ kammaṃ yaṃ hoti kaṭukapphalaṃ"* – performing evil kamma that bears bitter fruit, these foolish people live as enemies to themselves. Thus, while *kammabandhu* means kinsman, they can also become enemies if we contemplate in that way – in terms of unwholesomeness.

Therefore, contemplating that this law of kamma – the Dhamma of kamma – is operating in every event that happens to us often helps us to suppress sudden reactions, impatience, and anger, in accordance with the word of the Buddha. This is something that must be contemplated practically and constantly.

Likewise, through this story, another important matter is revealed to us: the importance of the five precepts. This five precepts (*pañca-sīla*) taught by the Buddha is not a trivial thing. Within this virtue (*sīla*), all the instances in this long saṃsāra where the mind of a being is inclined toward unwholesomeness are included in brief – in a simple way. The unwholesome kamma performed by us, taken generally, in one way or another, falls under either the first precept – the unwholesome act of taking life – or stealing (*adinnādāna*), or sexual misconduct (*kāmesu micchācāra*), or false speech (*musāvāda*), or taking intoxicants (*surāpāna*) – principally. One can speak of various other branches of these, but these can be considered the main ones. Thus, it is the results of the evil deeds related to the five sins committed by us in past saṃsāra that we experience daily in various ways. Not only death as mentioned earlier, but illnesses, various disasters, destruction of wealth and crops, and various other daily troubles – the cause for every single one of these is the dangerous unwholesome kamma performed by oneself in the past. Yet, the danger of kamma does not end there. As mentioned just now, because of not knowing the true nature of kamma, one entangles the ball of karmic threads.

Indeed, the Buddha compares this saṃsāra to a tangled ball of thread. How does it become a tangled ball of thread? A certain result comes to us according to the kamma we have performed. When that result comes, we do not know how it happened. We entangle it further. We entangle it by generating more kamma through it. By harboring hatred towards the persons who became instrumental in bringing about that result – and not only that, but by succumbing to various other defilements (*kilesa*) arising from it, we entangle kamma. We accumulate more and more kamma. Thus, there is such a dangerous situation in the entanglement of kamma. It is not only oneself who falls into this entanglement. When performing a kamma, and when experiencing its results, there are others who join in. There are also people who rejoice in it (*anumodana*). Now, we know that after giving alms or performing some other valuable meritorious deed, we share those merits with others. On such occasions, there is an opportunity for those departed ones to rejoice in that merit and generate some wholesome state so that they do not go to woeful states but to happy realms. That is the good side. We usually use the word *anumodanā* (rejoicing/sharing merit) in relation to wholesomeness. But, devotees, we frequently see in society that there are also occasions where unwholesomeness is rejoiced in.

Especially in this day and age, you know very well: when one's friends obtain some gain, even in an indirect manner, one rejoices over it. If that is an unwholesome act, if that person accomplished that deed in a wrong way, what we are doing there is rejoicing in that unwholesomeness. Or else, especially if a friend of ours has committed some grave act – let us say, wrong view (*micchā-

ditṭhi*), stealing, or various other corrupt acts – we either help them through body or speech, or rejoice in mind, saying, "Oh, that is very good." To say nothing of other things, if one's enemy dies, there is a habit among beings, deluded by kamma, to rejoice in it by saying "Sādhū! Sādhū!". What does one do by that? Taking upon oneself something that was passing by – or something that did not belong to oneself – one binds oneself to that unwholesome kamma. Thus, although the word *anumodanā* is used in relation to wholesomeness, we unknowingly rejoice in unwholesomeness as well. This happens because of that very ignorance. That rejoicing (*anumodanā*) is also a kamma. Even if it was done by someone else in the past, when one rejoices in mind, one's own *Vedanā* (Feeling) is defiled by it. Through that, one accumulates unwholesome kamma for oneself. One must be careful of such situations.

Now, there are various kinds of parties and sides in the world. But the Dhamma mentions two sides that exist eternally in the world: *Sura* and *Asura* (gods and titans). There is always a battle between these two sides. The Buddha declares that at a time when Tathāgatas arise in the world, at that time the side of the *Suras* – that is, the devas – grows strong, while the side of the *Asuras* – that is, the yakkhas – becomes weak, feeble, and their numbers decrease. What does this mean? When beings incline toward wholesomeness, more devas arise in the world. Next, as they incline more and more toward unwholesomeness, those who are born in lower realms like yakkhas and pretas increase. There is such a competition in the world. This can be shown as dark and bright (black and white). When we contemplate in terms of Dhamma, the conflict between wholesome and unwholesome can be taken as white and black – the white side is wholesomeness, the black side is unwholesomeness. These are the two sides that exist eternally in the world, not the other parties we think of. Therefore, we must contemplate which side we belong to, and which side we are supporting (voting for) – the black side or the white side. Voting for the white side is called *kusala-chanda* (wholesome desire) in the Dhamma – *kusala-chanda*. One votes for wholesomeness. There is also a bad side of voting (desire), which is called *chanda-rāga* (lustful desire). That goes toward unwholesomeness. If one develops an attachment that inclines toward the lust of *chanda-rāga*, it goes to the bad side. *Kusala-chanda* is a good thing because it is a certain noble aspiration or a desire for the Dhamma that ends in Nibbāna. We must contemplate that there are two such forces in the world. If we do not properly shape our lives in this manner according to the Buddha's Dhamma, we cannot say in what abyss this journey of ours will end. Such is the situation.

Therefore, we must especially contemplate the observation of virtue (*sīla*). Even on this occasion, you have observed virtue – the *Ājīva-aṭṭhamaka-sīla* (eight precepts with livelihood as the eighth), or the Uposatha eight precepts, or

some have observed the ten precepts. In this manner, a certain virtue has been observed. The Buddha has briefly explained the concept of wholesome and unwholesome to the Venerable Rāhula: unwholesome (*akusala*) means those actions done through mind, body, or speech that lead to one's own harm and the harm of others. That is what unwholesome means. Wholesome (*kusala*) means those actions done through mind, body, and speech that lead to one's own well-being and the well-being of others. Thus, when one understands it in this way, this is not a short-term view that the Buddha is presenting. One might think, "I am getting a profit at this moment." But when contemplating in accordance with kamma, one should not adopt such a short-term view.

Now, someone might commit theft or some such deed, thinking, "This is beneficial to me." But in truth, it causes harm to others. Not only that, one's own mind is defiled. We must contemplate with wisdom in this manner. We have a power within us to think in this way, which is called reflection (*paccavekkhaṇā*). We must bring that forward. Likewise, by instilling that wisdom and a certain power of determination into the mind, what closely follows is called reviewing (*āvajjanā*) – reviewing one's virtue (*sīla-āvajjanā*).

We must think about its value. What a valuable thing the Buddha has declared as virtue (*sīla*). In this path of Dhamma, virtue is only the first step. Yet, how valuable is even that which is contained within it? This training of body and speech is also something that must be done systematically.

Virtue (*sīla*) means "tamed-ness" (*hīlāṅkama*), if we translate it into Sinhala. We see the value of this tamed-ness when we look at the value of a disciplined elephant. The mahout, taming that huge beast, makes it perform various tasks. Similarly, one rides on the back of a fast-running horse, having tamed it, and works in that manner. In this way, when even a wild animal is systematically tamed, what wondrous tasks can it be made to perform! How much benefit can one derive from it!

In that way, if we train our body and speech according to this virtue (*sīla*) declared by the Buddha – next, what is contained in it is not merely body and speech. Our bodies are not machines. The mind is what helps to activate these things called body and speech, in accordance with the phrase *"Manopubbaṅgamā dhammā"* ("Mind precedes all mental states"). The primary cause for this is the mind. Indeed, what is contained in this virtue – as the Sangha expresses it, referring to the saying "like the village headman observing precepts" – is not a mindless taking of precepts without understanding. One must take it to heart. Even though we say it in Pāli to be more dharmic and respectful, we must understand its meaning. This precept regarding killing animals, or rather,

abstaining from killing animals – *veramaṇī* means abstaining – here *"veramaṇī"* or *"virati"* means abstaining. That is the difficult part. Doing is easy; abstaining is difficult. To say "I undertake and observe" that precept of abstaining, that rule of self-discipline, means to voluntarily – not because someone else said so – make a resolution in one's mind to keep it. It is like giving a command to one's own wisdom. In our behavior, there are things done habitually/capriciously, and there are things done with wisdom. There is a great difference between these two. Each of us has a certain power within us, a thing called "wisdom" – what we call conscious wisdom – the ability to do something mindfully. But that is something that must be brought out with effort. Why? The nature of saṃsāra is to flow downwards towards unwholesomeness, like a stream of water. Therefore, wisdom remains suppressed. Usually, we act according to our whims, according to the mind, and that mind which is on the surface is mostly inclined towards unwholesomeness. But there is a thing called wisdom, a certain strength, a wisdom (*paññā*) within us. There is an understanding within us. That is the very concept of reflection (*paccavekkhaṇā*). If we look deeply at the word reflection – it is like someone going in front of a mirror and looking at himself. It is to pause and think about something.

The Buddha has briefly explained the concept of wholesome and unwholesome to Venerable Rāhula: unwholesome means those actions done through mind, body, or speech that lead to one's own harm and the harm of others. Thus, when one understands it in this way, this is not a short-term view that the Buddha is presenting. There is a certain power within us called reflection (*paccavekkhaṇā*). We must bring that forward. Likewise, by instilling that wisdom and a certain power of determination into the mind, what closely follows is called reviewing – reviewing one's virtue (*sīla-āvajjanā*).

Reviewing (*āvajjanā*) means examining one's virtue again: "I have observed such and such a virtue. Is my behavior in accordance with this virtue?" At this moment, to remind oneself that one has observed the precepts, some even make a change in their clothing. What all of this does is to signal to oneself that one is established in virtue. Next, taking that into the heart, one tries to live in a manner corresponding to that behavior. It is through this that one is able to discipline the mind. First, one disciplines body and speech. The Buddha has pointed out that through this itself, one experiences great happiness in daily life.

That is called the happiness of blamelessness (*anavajja-sukha*) – blamelessness. The peace of knowing that we live without doing wrong. Now, how many people today live with regret? The benefit of virtue is to live daily with peaceful Dhamma, free from regret – what is called the state of being free from remorse (*avippaṭisāra*). To the person who commits unwholesome deeds,

during daily life activities, it may not come to mind, but perhaps when going to sleep, he remembers, "Did I do such things?" Especially in old age, or at the moment of death, that unwholesome deed comes to mind. At the moment of death, if a grave unwholesome kamma comes to mind, one goes straight to woeful states. There is such a dangerous situation in saṃsāra. This is why the Buddha ultimately declares to escape from this entire great saṃsāra. Escaping from saṃsāra means completely freeing oneself from that entanglement of kamma mentioned earlier. One cannot escape from it by some ordinary means. It is like an incredibly wondrous tangled ball of thread. That is why a Buddha is necessary to escape from this entanglement of kamma – or rather, to escape from saṃsāra.

A Buddha is one who, having escaped himself, explains to beings the Dhamma that helps them also to escape. That method is supramundane liberation (*lokuttara-vimutti*) – the transcendental liberation shown by the Buddhas, which is crossing over the world. It is through this that this entanglement of kamma can be untangled. The primary cause for all of this is pointed out as *Saṅkhāra* (Formations). It is said that these things happen because of *saṅkhāra*. Some of you may have heard that a Sotāpanna – that is, one who, based on virtue, has stilled the mind with concentration (*samādhi*), and through wisdom (*paññā*), which is the realization of the truth: that existence in the world is *Dukkha* (Suffering), the cause for this is *Taṇhā* (Craving), the stilling of this *taṇhā* is Nibbāna, and the path to it is the Noble Eightfold Path – must realize these four facts to a certain extent. In other words, one must realize the three characteristics of this entire existence: *Anicca* (Impermanent), *Dukkha* (Suffering), and *Anattā* (Not-self). Having realized them in this way, a dispassion, a weariness toward this saṃsāric existence must arise in the mind. As long as there is no weariness toward this, one cannot escape from saṃsāra. When various disasters and calamities occur in daily life, everyone feels for a moment in their mind: "Oh, there is no substance in this saṃsāric existence." But because ignorance and *taṇhā* operate in the mind in a dangerous manner, that is forgotten. Such is the situation. Therefore, the Buddha declares that by systematically developing virtue, concentration, and wisdom, and by correctly contemplating with wisdom to develop wisdom, if at some point the mind reaches the state of a Sotāpanna, through that path-knowledge, those four truths are directly realized.

It is said that because of ignorance, *Saṅkhāra* (Formations) arise. Thus, due to that feeling of "I" and "mine" which is taken as "self," numerous mental preparations occur. Briefly, it can be called *Vedanā* (Feeling), aspirations, hopes, which are a succession of thoughts. There is a mental activity. That activity takes us into a state like that great tangled ball of thread in saṃsāra. It is the

wholesome and unwholesome kamma performed by us that keeps us alive for a long time.

Therefore, in order to escape from this, one must still this force of *Vedanā* (Feeling), this force of kamma, or rather this momentum of *Saṅkhāra* (Formations). It must be calmed, it must be extinguished. It is such a thing that the Buddhas present as supramundane liberation. Through the penetration of the path and fruit, through path-knowledges, through the four path-fruits of Sotāpanna, Sakadāgāmi, Anāgāmi, and Arahant, the Buddhas solve this entire great problem of saṃsāra – this entanglement of kamma. In brief, we can think of it in this way:

Everyone has heard that a Sotāpanna – who, based on virtue, has stilled the mind with concentration, and through wisdom, which is the realization of the truth: that existence in the world is *Dukkha* (Suffering), the cause for this is *Taṇhā* (Craving), the stilling of this *taṇhā* is Nibbāna, and the path to it is the Noble Eightfold Path – must realize these four facts to a certain extent. In other words, a Sotāpanna lay disciple who has understood the three characteristics of this entire existence: *Anicca* (Impermanent), *Dukkha* (Suffering), and *Anattā* (Not-self) – that is, one who has stilled the mind with concentration based on virtue – such a person, through that path-knowledge, limits future lifetimes to a maximum of seven, destroying all other karmic forces. Especially, kamma leading to lower realms is eradicated. That is why the Buddha has declared that even the liberation obtained through the first path-knowledge, called Sotāpanna, is greater than universal monarchy. We must contemplate in this manner. That is the first level.

Next, the second level is shown as the state of Sakadāgāmi (Once-returner). Sakadāgāmi means that at this second level, the person's wisdom exhausts other kammas, leaving only what is required for one more existence in the deva world and one in the human world. Indeed, Sakadāgāmi means returning to this world only once more. It is possible to be born once in the deva world and then return to the human world. Next, in the one who has reached the state of Anāgāmi (Non-returner), the mind breaks many of those fetters (*saṃyojana*) bound to *Bhava* (Becoming), and takes birth in the Brahma realms called the Suddhāvāsa (Pure Abodes), attaining Parinibbāna right there. Then, only the subtle kamma to be experienced in the Suddhāvāsa remains. Next, at the stage of Arahantship, if there are any kammas that give results as *diṭṭhadhammavedanīya* (to be experienced in this life), those alone are left, and all other karmic forces are stilled. The mind is brought to a state where it does not bring about another birth – through the power of wisdom. That is what is called the stilling of preparations (*saṅkhāra*) – *"Sabba-saṅkhāra-samatho"*. A name

for Nibbāna itself is the calming of all preparations (*saṅkhāra*). Thus, through this array of words: calming, stilling, tranquilizing, extinguishing, what is shown is how the Buddhas solved this problem of saṃsāra – through understanding, through wisdom, through purification.

In that way, the Buddhas have shown this path of Dhamma. Accordingly, we must contemplate how we should spend our lives. Now, in a few days, you are preparing to step into a new year, a new century. We must think a little about what this past century was. Materially speaking, it was a century that progressed toward development through wondrous productions. But spiritually speaking, it was an era that faced a dangerous decline. The reason for this might be having a wrong understanding of that material progress – of its value. Through that very material progress, they must have accumulated causes for their spiritual decline. Because, you know that in daily life people say they have no opportunity to practice meditation, that there is no time in the day. The reason for this can be guessed from the situation in households. Thus, the very thing we call material progress has become the cause of our decline.

Therefore, we must strive to gain a correct understanding of the value of life, what we call our core virtues, by examining them with wisdom, and by reflecting on Dhamma stories of this kind. This is not something of today or yesterday, nor is it confined to that time, or to the lay disciple Mahākāla alone; these are things that happen to all of us. Contemplating the law contained in these according to the word of the Buddha, we must strive to develop the path that helps us escape from saṃsāra: the Noble Eightfold Path, and the threefold training – even amidst obstacles. For this can only be done during the period of a Buddha's dispensation (*buddhotpāda-kāla*). In a period when no Buddha arises, we would not even hear the word "Nibbāna". Even if we heard it, we would not understand it. It is such a rare opportunity. Therefore, in whatever way we contemplate a century, in truth we live only for this single moment. We live only for this moment.

Everything we call life and existence lasts only for an extremely brief instant. The moment that instant breaks, it is finished right there. But we entangle ourselves through ignorance and *Taṇhā* (Craving). This is the truth that one must directly realize through meditation. We must directly realize this truth of *Anicca* (Impermanent) declared by the Buddha in our own minds. We must see this. It is through that seeing that the entangling stops. *Upādāna* (grasping/holding/fuel) means holding on. The mind is always holding onto something, extremely rapidly. Like a monkey jumping from tree to tree in a forest, this mind goes on holding. Thus, seeing this activity of the mind is what is called contemplation in insight (*vipassanā*). We must train ourselves to see how this mind operates with a concentrated mind. We must control our lives through the three doors of body, speech, and mind – using the precepts declared by the

Buddha. Next, also regarding the six doors of the eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind – because it is through these doors that unwholesomeness flows in. Turning the mind away from these, next, by keeping the mind on a wholesome sign (*kusala-nimitta*) through some pure meditation subject (*kammaṭṭhāna*) for a long time, one must experience the power of concentration – the strength of one's mind. It is with such a concentrated mind that one can see the true nature of one's five aggregates (*pañcakkhandha*) and the true nature of the world. That is the supramundane liberation declared by the Buddha. Indeed, escaping from this entanglement of kamma is possible only through the Dhamma. The powerful force of this law of kamma can be broken only by the wheel of Dhamma.

Therefore, this pious congregation must contemplate: we must strive to make a significant correction to our daily lifestyle. If you think of a new beginning, or if you think that according to some worldly convention we are facing a new century, instead of thinking about those other useless things, you should think about the core virtues of life, and shape your daily lifestyle accordingly. Shape your daily routine. Shape your timetable. Also, an important thing is one's livelihood (*ājīva*) – one's way of living. This is an era where livelihoods are turning towards unrighteousness in a dangerous way, an era that allows unrighteous livelihoods from every side. But you must contemplate: are you going to shorten saṃsāra, or are you going to go on and on in saṃsāra, in the midst of such a mass of *Dukkha* (Suffering)? If we dislike *Dukkha* (Suffering), we must not do the things that cause *Dukkha* (Suffering). We do not knowingly drink poison. We do not knowingly put poison into the well from which we drink water. If that is the case, we must contemplate not to become an enemy to ourselves. We must rise up through that very path of Dhamma declared by the Buddha.

Now we hear some people say these days – some theorists and sophists – that even by performing wholesome deeds, *Bhava* (Becoming) increases. Therefore, they say one should not do them either. That is a wrong view. What is here is the Middle Path (*majjhimā paṭipadā*). We use the wholesome to escape from the unwholesome. Through that wholesomeness, we develop good conduct – it is through this that concentration arises. By removing regrets from the mind, concentration arises. Therefore, according to the Middle Path, everything like giving alms and performing meritorious deeds is useful. However, one does not stop there. Once the mind is prepared, what does one do next? One develops insight meditation (*vipassanā-bhāvanā*) which aids wisdom. That is the situation. Without getting entangled in myths, without catching the snake by its tail, like crossing over a flood, we must use all of these as aids and strive to direct our mind toward Nibbāna.

Then, if we contemplate a next century or a next year, we must develop enough strength to advise, speak to, and teach the Dhamma we know to our children and everyone else so that their lives are shaped accordingly, acting as spiritual friends (*kalyāṇa-mitta*). That strength can be developed only by engaging in the Dhamma oneself. If one observes the precepts in this manner and meditates oneself, when facing a crisis in life, or when someone comes with a problem as if asking for a loan, if that person has fallen into a dangerous life, one will have the verbal power to prevent them in accordance with the Dhamma. Such spiritual friends are sometimes found among those who have turned to this path of Dhamma.

Therefore, we hope that this pious congregation, walking on this path of Dhamma, in this era which is heading towards a dangerous abyss, will save themselves at least through others (by following others) – saving themselves from this abyss – turning to the path of Dhamma, realizing the dangerous nature of saṃsāra mentioned here. Through that, no matter how many duties and chores you have in your daily routine, you must make a beginning, even for a short time. Sometimes people complain, saying, "We have to spend the early part of the day on these activities." Such people should gain time anew, at least by waking up 10 or 15 minutes earlier. If such a beginning is made, there is room for the benefit of that wholesome desire (*kusala-chanda*); even if one performs a brief meditation, through the benefits arising from it, one's energy will grow. It will grow rapidly. Furthermore, the association of spiritual friends (*kalyāṇa-mitta*) is essential. According to the declaration made by the Buddha, this entire dispensation (*sāsana*) is spiritual friendship. Therefore, while striving to be a spiritual friend oneself, one must make use of other spiritual friends. Even with difficulty, one must meet them, take their advice, and strive to carry on these activities.

Now, if you contemplate in that manner and train yourselves to perform your daily activities and direct your thoughts while reflecting on the danger of kamma, that will help you abstain from misconduct and incline toward good conduct. Thinking in this way, today, on this valuable Uposatha day – the Uposatha day that ends the year – it is a good opportunity to make certain special determinations. Thus, having observed a valuable virtue on this occasion, disciplining mind, body, and speech, and conducting your mind, body, and speech in a manner that generates and develops the spiritual faculties (*indriya*) and powers (*bala*) – namely, faith (*saddhā*), energy (*viriya*), mindfulness (*sati*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*) – you have listened to the Dhamma during this hour. As the benefit of these, without postponing them to a distant future, you must resolve to obtain the full fruits and benefits of these in these very moments and escape from this extremely dangerous saṃsāra.

For this purpose, you must pray: "May this store of merit accumulated today through the disciplining of mind, body, and speech, and by listening to the Dhamma, definitely be a supportive cause for us to escape from the *Dukkha* (Suffering) of saṃsāra!" Likewise, may whatever group of devas and Brahmas there are in this universe who protect the Dispensation rejoice with happy minds in the store of merit accumulated by us through listening to the Dhamma and preaching the Dhamma! May they have the strength and power to protect the world and the Dispensation, fulfilling their spiritual perfections (*pāramīs*)! May all of them realize the supreme, deathless, great Nibbāna through a bodhi of their aspiration! We must share merits with those devas in this manner. Likewise, whatever departed relatives of ours there may be, and all beings from Avīci up to Akaniṭṭha, including them, may they rejoice in this merit of listening to and preaching the Dhamma! May this merit be a cause for them to escape from the *dukkha* of saṃsāra consisting of the extremely dangerous *Jāti* (Birth), *jarāmaraṇa* (decay and death/aging and death), sickness, and to be pacified by the supreme, deathless, great Nibbāna! Share merits in this manner by reciting these stanzas:

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”